

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open –

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

– and into the middle of it.

The room is already loud. Two mugs on the side table. One steaming. One dead cold. A chair pushed out at a wrong angle. This has been going a while.

MAYA, 30s, coat still on because she never got the chance to take it off. JAMES, 30s, halfway across the room from her, hands up, backing away from the sentence he just started.

The camera settles off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases – a body that has decided it isn't alone. It is the wrong moment for it.

MAYA

– no. No, finish it. You opened your mouth, so finish it.

JAMES

I wasn't going to say anything.

MAYA

You were about to say something and then you left. Say it.

JAMES

There's nothing to–

MAYA

There is ALWAYS something. There is always a room you're standing in that I am not allowed into and I am so –

JAMES

Here we go.

MAYA

Don't. Don't "here we go" me like
I'm the weather.

He turns from her. Crosses to the window. Shoves it open.
Cold pours in.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Are you serious.

JAMES

It's hot in here.

MAYA

It is not hot, James. It's me. I'm
the thing that's too much. Just say
that instead.

JAMES

I didn't say that.

MAYA

You opened a window in November.
You would rather freeze in a field
than stand in a warm room with me
for one more —

He slams it shut. The glass jumps in the frame.

JAMES

There. Happy?

MAYA

No! No, I'm not — do I look happy
to you? Do I look like a happy —

JAMES

What do you want. Tell me the
actual words and I'll —

MAYA

I want you to look at me.

JAMES

I'm looking at you.

MAYA

For one whole sentence. Start to
finish. Without —

She stops. She doesn't have the word for it. Her hand gestures at the air beside him, the nothing.

MAYA (CONT'D)

— without going wherever it is you go.

JAMES

I'm right here. I have been standing here the entire —

MAYA

You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES

Oh my god.

MAYA

Two. I watched you.

JAMES

I miscounted, Maya, it's a —

MAYA

You don't miscount. You count MY drinks. You counted them at dinner last night, one two three, I watched you do the little —

JAMES

Because you were —

MAYA

I was WHAT. Say it. Go on. For once in your life land the hit instead of walking out of the room while it's still in your hand.

A beat. He stops backing away. Turns. His voice drops and gets worse.

JAMES

You were performing. Like you always do. You host the argument. You booked the cottage, you booked the fight, you put us in your calendar in a little colour — who does that, who schedules the conversation where their marriage —

MAYA

At least I show up to it.

JAMES
You show up to run it.

MAYA
Somebody has to be in the room,
because you are NOT, you have not
been in a single –

JAMES
I am IN the room –

MAYA
Then LOOK at me –

She crosses the space and takes his face in both hands.
Forces it to hers.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. Is it that hard. Am I that
hard to –

He pulls his head free. Steps back.

JAMES
Don't grab me.

MAYA
Then stay in your own face. You
leave your own eyes, do you know
that? Mid-word. Every time. You go.

He's breathing hard. And then – he can't help it – his head
tips. A fraction. Toward the space beside him. That
listening.

She sees it happen. In real time. It takes the fight out of
her and puts something worse in.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(quiet, wrecked)
You're doing it. Right now. I am
screaming at you in the middle of
nowhere and you are somewhere else
even now.

The camera drifts closer to him. He almost turns his cheek
to it.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Say my name.

JAMES
Maya –

MAYA
You had to find me first. You
looked for me. In our own – you had
to look.

He comes at her. Fast. Not gentle – a collision. He grabs her. She shoves him hard in the chest, and then fists his shirt and pulls him back in. Rage and want, no daylight between them.

She bites his shoulder. Hard. He makes a sound. Holds her by the arms too tight, his face turned away, over her head – his eyes open. Finding the space.

JAMES
(into her hair, breaking)
I am trying. You have no idea how
hard I am –

MAYA
Trying to what. To stay? You can't
even –

And his eyes fix on the empty air where the camera hovers. Something goes out of his face.

He lets go of her. Steps back.

MAYA (CONT'D)
What. What is it –

JAMES
No.

MAYA
James. Look at me. What –

He's not looking at her. He steps back again, into the room, and his hand comes up – reaching toward the nothing beside him. Palm open. At a height. As if to find a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. What he's doing. The reach. The two mugs. The dead-cold cup. The window he keeps opening. The whole shape of the evening laid out like evidence against him.

His face comes apart.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug goes to the floor and smashes.

MAYA
(flinching back)
James —

He isn't looking at her. He's looking at the empty air. He backs away from it and it follows him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
Not tonight. Not now. Not — GO —

MAYA
Who are you talking to —

JAMES
(a roar, ragged, at
nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS — a hard rush back, away from him, across the room, over the broken mug, out through the gap in the window —

EXT. COTTAGE / FELS - CONTINUOUS

— out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing hard. The gold window shrinking beneath it.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high above the roof. Looks down.

Down at the little lit cottage. Down at the one warm window with the man in it. Small now. Both hands over his face.

And Maya, frozen behind him — staring at the man she loves screaming at an empty room, a smashed cup at his feet, and nothing, nothing there.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.